adaptable, but never more so than in war. The Taliban had worked out exactly how many minutes they had from first contact with our troops until the cavalry came over the horizon, and their internal clocks were finely calibrated: they'd shoot at as many guys as possible, then bolt.

They'd got better at hiding too. They could effortlessly melt into a village, blend into the civilian population, or vaporize into their network of tunnels. They didn't run away—it was far more diffuse than that, more mystical.

We didn't give up the search easily. We'd circle, sweep back and forth, sometimes for two hours. (The Apache ran out of fuel after two hours.) Sometimes, at the end of two hours, we'd still be unwilling to give up. So we'd refuel.

One day we refueled three times, spending a total of eight hours in the air.

When we finally returned to base the situation was dire: I'd run out of piss bags.

53.

I WAS THE FIRST in my squadron to pull the trigger in anger.

I remember the night as well as any in my life. We were in the VHR tent, the red phone rang, we all sprinted to the aircraft. Dave and I raced through preflight checks, I gathered the mission details: One of the control points closest to Bastion had come under small arms fire. We needed to get there, ASAP, and find out where the fire was coming from. We took off, swept over the wall, went vertical, climbed to fifteen hundred feet. Moments later I swung the night sight onto the target area. *There!*

Eight hot spots, eight kilometers away. Thermal smudges—walking from where the contact had been.

Dave said: *That's got to be them!*